

Standard 1: PROGRAMME MISSION, OBJECTIVES AND OUTCOMES

1: Expectation:

Each program must have a mission, measurable objectives and expected outcomes for graduates. Outcomes include competency and tasks graduates are expected to perform after completing the programme. A strategic plan must be in place to achieve the programme objectives. The extent to which these objectives are achieved through continuous assessment and improvements must be demonstrated.

1.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

The program must have documented measurable objectives that support Faculty / College and institution mission statements.

1.1.1 Document institution, college and program mission statements

<u>University Mission Statement:</u>
<u>Institute / College Mission Statement:</u>
<u>Program Mission Statement:</u>

Indicative Evidence: Evidence of Vision Mission genesis/approval.

1.1.2 State Program Educational Objectives:

(Program educational objectives are intended to be statements that describe the expected accomplishments of graduates during the first several years following graduation from the program.)

<u>Program Objectives:</u> i. ii. iii. iv.
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1.1.3 Describe how each objective is aligned with the institution mission statements.

Program Objectives	Institute/college Mission Statement
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1.1.4. Outline the main elements of the strategic plan to achieve the programme objectives.

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1.1.5. Provide for each objective how it was measured, when it was measured and improvements Identified and made. (Use Alumni and Alumni survey, Focus group interview of employers and alumni, Job Placement & Career Progression Data, Community & professional engagement, results of Standardized exams, Advisory Board Input etc.

Following Table provides a format for program objectives assessment.

Objective	How measured	When measured	Improvement identified	Improvement made

Table 1.1.5: Program objectives assessment

Indicative Evidence: Results of Surveys (Alumni/Employer)

National Database/published reports/

- i. conduct a survey of alumni every two years
- ii. conduct a survey of employers every two years (other tools may be used as needed)

1.2 Expectation Outcome Indicators (EOIs)

The program must have documented outcomes for graduating students. It must be demonstrated that the outcomes support the program objectives and that graduating students are capable of performing these outcomes.

List the Program Outcomes (around 7-13 PLOs to be listed below):

1. ..
2. ..
3. ..

1.2.1 Describe how the programme outcomes support the programme objectives.

Table 1.2.1: Outcomes versus objectives

Program Objectives	Program Outcomes							
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
i								
ii								
iii								
iv								
v								
vi								
vii								

1.2.2 Describe the means for assessing the extent to which graduates are performing the stated program outcomes/learning objectives. This should be accomplished by the following:

This should be accomplished by the following:

- i. conducting a survey of graduating seniors every semester
- ii. carefully designed questions asked during senior projects presentations; these questions should be related to programme outcomes.
- iii. Outcomes examinations (Exit Exam)
- iv. Results of Capstone Courses/assignment
- v. Mapping results

Program Learning Outcomes	How Assessed	Results & Improvement Identified/made
1.		
2.		

3.		
4.		

Indicative Evidence:

The data obtained from the above sources should be analyzed and presented in the assessment report. It is recommended that the above surveys should be conducted, summarized and added to the self-assessment report. Departments should utilize the results of the surveys for improving the programme as soon as they are available.

1.3 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

The results of programme's accreditation and the extent to which they are used to improve the programme must be documented.

1.3.1 Describe the actions taken based on the results of periodic accreditation

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Indicative Evidence: Compliance of last Accreditation Report/PGPR.

1.3.2 Describe major future program improvements plans based on recent assessments.

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1.3.3 List strengths and weaknesses of the program

Program Strengths	Program Weaknesses

1.3.4 List significant future development plans for the program.

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1.4 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

1.4.1 The department must assess its overall performance periodically using quantifiable measures.

Performance Measures	Results
Present student enrolments (undergraduate and graduate) during the last three years indicating percentages of honours students	
Student faculty ratio	
Average graduating grade point average per semester	
Average time for completing the program	
Attrition rate	
Percentage of employers that are strongly satisfied with the performance of the department's graduates (employer Survey)	
Indicate the median/average student evaluation for all modules	
% of faculty awarded excellence in teaching award	
No. of journal publications per faculty per year	
No. of funded projects	
No. of conference publications per faculty per year	
% of faculty awarded excellence in research award	
Number of short courses per year, workshops and seminars organized for community services	
Faculty and students satisfaction regarding the administrative services offered by the department	

Indicative Evidence: Evidence of data of the above indicators.

1.5 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

The department/programme must take deliberate steps to engage all students, individually and collectively, as partners in the assurance and enhancement of their educational experience.

1.5.1. Describe actions taken to involve students in the evaluation of teaching and learning.

1.5.2 Describe actions taken as a result of student evaluation.

1.5.3 Describe how actions are communicated to students.

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1.5.4 Describe actions taken to engage students in decision-making about the quality of their higher education.

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1.5.5 Describe actions taken to recruit student members to appropriate deliberative committees.

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1.5.6 Describe training given to students to enable their participation in decision-making committees.

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1.5.7 Terms of reference of deliberative committees on which students sit.

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Indicative Evidence: Students Inclusion evidence/notification with ROR.

Indicative evidence (Generic)

1. Programme specification clarifying programme missions, objectives and outcomes
2. Academic development plan clarifying how to develop programme structure, curriculums, and resources
3. Analysis reports of the process adopted for development of mission and subsequent goals and periodic reviews of mission and goals
4. Analysis reports of the process of application of these goals and coordination for implementation
5. Review reports of processes adopted to disseminate the mission and goals to
 - i. faculty, students and members of the governing body and efforts to maintain the
 - ii. institution's commitment to the mission among members of the institution

Standard-2: CURRICULUM DESIGN AND ORGANIZATION

The curriculum must be designed and organized to achieve the program's objectives and outcomes. Also course objectives must be in line with program outcomes. The breakdown of the curriculum must satisfy the standards specified in this section. Curriculum standards are specified in terms of credit hours of study. A semester credit hour equals one class hour or two to three laboratory hours per week. The semester is approximately fifteen weeks.

Provide the following information about the programme's curriculum:

Program Specification Template:

Information Required	Information Provided
Title of degree program.	
Definition of credit hour	
Degree plan (attach a flow-chart showing the prerequisites, core, and elective courses)	
Curriculum breakdown in terms of mathematics and basic sciences, major requirements, social sciences and other requirements (Please fill Table 2.0)	

Semester	Course Code	Course Title	Core/Elective	Credit Hour (Theory-Lab)

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Table 2.1: Curriculum course requirements

Course Specification Template:

For each course in the program that can be counted for credit, provide the following details:

Information Required	Information Provided
Course title	
Course Learning Outcomes	
Catalog description	
Text book(s) and references	
Syllabus breakdown in lectures	
Computer usage	
Laboratory	
Detailed Course Outline (please attach)	

Indicative Evidence: Program Specification with Course details.

2.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

2.1.1 The curriculum must be consistent and supports the program's documented objectives.

Describe how the program content (courses) meets the program objectives

Courses	Program objectives						
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Table: 2.1.1

2.1.2 Complete the matrix shown in Table 2.1.2

linking courses to program outcomes. List the courses and mark the contribution of the course against relevant outcomes with I, R, M/A . (Introduced the Concept, Reinforced the Concept, Mastery/Assess

the concept.)

Courses	Program Learning Outcomes (PLOs)								
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9

Table 2.1.2: Courses versus program outcomes

2.2 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

Theoretical background, problems analysis and solution design must be stressed within the program's core material.

Indicate which courses contain a significant portion (more than 30%) of the following elements:

All the courses listed in Table 4.4 comprise of theoretical background (40-50%), problem analysis (30-40%) and solution design (30-40%). For problem analysis, group work and assignments are given. For Solution design student either prepare a term paper or project presentations on related skills acquired from each course.

Elements	Courses
Theoretical background	
Problem analysis	
Solution design	

Table 4.5: Standard 2-2 requirement

2.3 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

The curriculum must satisfy the core requirements for the program, as specified by the respective accreditation body.

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2.4 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

The curriculum must satisfy the major requirements for the program as specified by HEC, the respective accreditation body / councils.

2.5 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

The curriculum must satisfy general education, arts, and professional and other discipline requirements for the program, as specified by the respective accreditation body / council.

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2.6 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

Information technology component of the curriculum must be integrated throughout the program.

2.7 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

Oral and written communication skills of the student must be developed and applied in the program.

2.8 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

Indicative Evidence: Evidence of 2.1 to 2.8 available in Program Specification.

Standard-3: Subject Specific Facilities

Expectation:

Subject-specific facilities must be adequately available and accessible to faculty members and students to support teaching and research activities.

Lab Specification Template:

Describe the laboratory/ computer facilities that are available for use in the program under assessment. Indicate for each lab the following

Information Required	Information Provided
Course title	
Location and area	
Objectives	
Adequacy for instruction	
Courses taught	
Software available if applicable	
Major Apparatus	
Major Equipment	
Safety regulations	

3.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): Laboratory manuals/documentation/instructions for experiments must be available and readily accessible to faculty and students.

3.1.1 Describe the subject-specific facilities that are available for use in the programme under assessment..

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Indicative Evidence: List of facilities (verified)

3.1.2 Explain how students and faculty have adequate and timely access to the manuals/documentation and instructions.

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Indicative Evidence: Sample Manual

3.1.3 Benchmark with similar departments in reputable institutions to identify shortcomings in laboratory.

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3.2 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): There must be adequate support personnel for instruction and maintaining the laboratories.

3.2.1. Indicate for each laboratory: support personnel, level of support, nature and extent of instructional support.

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3.3 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): The institution's computing infrastructure and facilities must be adequate to support the programme's objectives

3.3.1 : Describe how the computing facilities support the computing component of the programme.

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3.3.2 : Benchmark with similar departments in reputable institutions to identify shortcomings in computing infrastructure and facilities.

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Indicative evidence for Standard-3 (Generic)

- **Comprehensive analysis reports of subject-specific facilities accessible to students and other stakeholders**
- **Subject-specific facilities development procedure and plan**
- **Subject-specific facilities usage record**
- **Annual review reports of student involvement and satisfaction with the provided facilities with practicable recommendations for further improvement**
- **Student feedback on subject-specific facilities**
- **Video evidence of resources**
- **Print or electronic review reports of availability of required subject-specific facilities reflected through student handbooks, catalogues, newspapers**

Criterion 4: STUDENT SUPPORT AND ADVISING

Expectations:

Student must have adequate support to complete the program in a timely manner and must have ample opportunity to interact with their instructors and receive timely advice about program requirements and career alternatives.

4.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs) 4: Modules must be offered with sufficient frequency and number for students to complete the programme in a timely manner..

4.1.1 Provide the department's strategy for course offerings.

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4.1.2 Explain how often required courses are offered.

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4.1.3 Explain how often elective courses are offered.

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4.1.4 Explain how required modules outside the department are managed to be offered in sufficient number and frequency.

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4.2 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs) : Modules in the major area of study must be structured to ensure effective interaction between students, department and teaching assistants.

Describe how you achieve effective student / faculty interaction in courses taught by more than one person such as two faculty members, a faculty member and a teaching assistant or a lecturer.

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4.3 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): Guidance on how to complete the programme 20

must be available to all students and access to academic advising must be available to make module decisions and career choices.

4.3.1 Describe how students are informed about program requirements.

4.3.2 Describe the advising system and indicate how its effectiveness is measured.

4.3.3 Describe the student counseling system and how students get professional counseling when needed.

4.3.4 Indicate if students have access to professional counseling; when necessary.

4.3.5 Describe opportunities available for students to interact with practitioners, and to have membership in technical and professional societies.

Indicative evidence

- Comprehensive analysis reports of student support services accessible to students and other stakeholders
- Student support procedures and records
- Review reports of student involvement and satisfaction with the provided advising and counselling services
- Periodic assessment reports of advising and counselling services with practicable recommendations for further improvement
- Student feedback on advising and counselling services

- Video evidence of resources
- Print or electronic review reports of availability of required students' advisory services reflected through student handbooks, catalogues, newspapers

Standard 5: TEACHING FACULTY/STAFF

Expectation

Teaching faculty/staff must be current and active in their discipline and have the necessary technical depth and breadth to support the programme. There must be enough department members to provide continuity and stability, to cover the curriculum adequately and effectively, and to allow for scholarly activities

Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

5.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): There must be enough full-time teaching staff who are committed to the programme to provide adequate coverage of the programme areas/modules with continuity and stability. The interests and qualifications of all teaching staff must be sufficient to teach all modules, plan, modify and update modules and curricula. All teaching staff should have a level of competence that would normally be obtained through graduate work in the discipline. The majority of the teaching staff should hold a PhD in the discipline and/or vocational experience in their area of expertise.

5.1.1 : Complete a table indicating programme areas and number of teaching staff in each area.

S#	Program Areas	Teaching Staff In Each Areas

5.1.2 : Each member of teaching staff should complete a CV.

Name of Teaching Staff	Designation	CV Submission status

5.1.3 : The totality of teaching staff is sufficient to deliver the programme curriculum and objectives.

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5.1.4 : Conduct feedback surveys each semester from students for evaluation of teaching and assessment (Provide the result analysis only)

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5.2 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs) : Teaching staff must remain current in the discipline and sufficient time must be provided for scholarly activities and professional development. Also, effective programmes for staff development must be in place.

5.2.1 Describe the criteria for teaching staff to be deemed current in the discipline and based on these criteria and information in the teaching staff member's CV, what percentage of them is current. The criteria should be developed by the department.

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5.2.2 Describe the means for ensuring that full-time teaching staff have sufficient time for scholarly and professional development.

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5.2.3 Describe existing teaching staff development programmes at the departmental and institutional levels. Demonstrate their effectiveness in achieving teaching staff development.

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5.2.4 Indicate how frequently faculty programmes are evaluated and if the evaluation results are used for improvement.

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5.3 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): All teaching staff should be motivated and have job satisfaction to excel in their profession.

5.3.1 Describe programmes and processes in place for staff motivation.

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5.3.2 Indicate how effective these programmes are.

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5.3.3 Survey teaching staff to measure motivation and job satisfaction

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Documented institution and programme's practices for faculty appointment, tenure Precepts and procedures, supervision, promotion, evaluation for both regular/full-time, part-time, adjunct and other faculty members

- Dissemination of evaluation criteria and procedures, review reports of teaching effectiveness, analysis of faculty peer review reports for teaching and scholarship
- Records of productivity in scholarship of teaching and research in the creation of knowledge, consistent with the mission of the institution
- Analysisreportsofcorrelationbetweenfacultyprofileandperformanceandstudentlearning outcomes

STANDARD 6: INSTITUTIONAL POLICIES AND PROCESS CONTROL

Expectation

The processes by which major functions are delivered must be in place, controlled, periodically reviewed, evaluated and continuously improved.

Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

6.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): The process by which students are admitted to the programme must be based on quantitative and qualitative criteria and clearly documented.

6.1.1 This process must be periodically evaluated to ensure that it is meeting its objectives.

Periodically Evaluation Status	

6.1.2 Describe the programme admission criteria at the institutional level or department if applicable.

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6.1.3 Describe policy regarding programme/credit transfer.

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Evidence: Document of Transfer Policy

6.1.4 Indicate how frequently the admission criteria are evaluated and if the evaluation results are used to improve the process

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6.2 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): The process by which students are registered on the programme and monitoring of students' progress to ensure timely completion of the programme must be documented This process must be periodically evaluated to ensure that it is meeting its objectives.

6.2.1 Describe how students are registered on the programme.

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6.2.2 Describe how students' academic progress is monitored and how their programme of study is verified to adhere to the degree requirements.

6.2.3 Indicate how frequently the process of registration and monitoring are evaluated and if the evaluation results are used to improve the process.

6.3 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs) 6: The process of recruiting and retaining highly qualified department members must be in place and clearly documented. Also, processes and procedures for department evaluation, and promotion must be consistent with the institution mission statement. These processes must be periodically evaluated to ensure that they are meeting with their objectives.

6.3.1 Describe the process used to ensure that highly qualified teaching staff are recruited to the programme.

6.3.2 Indicate methods used to retain excellent teaching staff members.

6.3.3 Indicate how evaluation and promotion processes are in line with the institution mission statement.

6.3.4 Indicate how frequently this process is evaluated and if the evaluation results are used to improve the process.

6.4 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): The process and procedures used to ensure that teaching and delivery of module material to the students emphasises active learning and that module learning outcomes are met. The process must be periodically evaluated to ensure that it is meeting its objectives.

6.4.1 Describe the process and procedures used to ensure that teaching and delivery of module material is effective and focus on students learning.

6.4.2 Indicate how frequently this process is evaluated and if the evaluation results are used to improve the process.

6.5 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): The process that ensures that graduates have completed the requirements of the programme must be based on standards, and effective and clearly documented procedures. This process must be periodically evaluated to ensure that it is meeting its objectives.

6.5.1 Describe the procedures used to ensure that graduates meet the programme requirements.

6.5.2 Describe when this procedure is evaluated and whether the results of this evaluation is used to improve the process.

Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs) 6.6: Programmes produce information for external audiences about the learning opportunities they offer that is fit for purpose, accessible and trustworthy.

6.6.1 Mission, values and overall strategy are publicly available on the institution's website.

6.6.2 The process for application and admission to the programme of study is clearly described to prospective students.

6.6.3 Information is made available to prospective students to help them select their programme with an understanding of the academic environment in which they will be studying and the support that will be made available to them.

Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs) 6.7: Programmes produce information for students about the learning opportunities they offer that is fit for purpose, accessible and trustworthy.

6.7.1 Information on the programme of study is made available to current students at the start of their programme and throughout their studies.

6.7.2 Programmes set out what they expect of current students and what current students can expect of the programme.

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6.7.3 When students leave their programme of study, they are issued with a detailed record of their studies, which gives evidence to others of the students' achievement in their academic programme.

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6.8 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): Programmes are managed to high ethical standards when dealing with faculty, staff, students and other stakeholders.

6.8.1 Programmes practice and exemplify the values and ethical principles articulated in the institution's mission and ethics policies.

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6.8.2 Programmes safeguard the interests of students, faculty and staff.

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6.8.3 Programmes ensure equality, diversity and inclusion.

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6.8.4 Programmes have a transparent approach to all communication, including academic integrity and complaints.

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Indicative evidence

- Marketing strategy
- Admissions policy

- Progression policy
 - Certification policy
 - Evidence of support programmes and services for students to improve the achievement of their educational goals and expected learning outcomes
 - Periodic review reports of information provided on financial aid programmes, scholarships and grants
 - Evidence of utilisation of review reports of financial aid component to further improve these and to assure the public information-sharing
 - Evidence of utilisation of review report results to further improve the policies of admission, retention, persistence, and so on
 - Evidence of utilisation of attrition data and drop-out analysis reports to investigate the reasons and to improve the situation for these students
 - Effective teaching and learning environments with appropriate resources
 - Demonstration of electronic resources to support teaching and learning, for example, a virtual learning environment (VLE)
 - Staff development programme and evidence of staff attendance
 - Examples of scholarship activities that support teaching and learning
 - Observation of teaching and learning procedure, results of observations and followup activities
 - Programme and module handbooks
 - Student support procedure and records
 - Student tutorial procedure and associated records
 - Student feedback on their learning experiences
- Guidelines Policies and processes are the main pillars of a coherent institutional quality assurance system that forms a cycle for continuous improvement and contributes to the accountability of the institution and its programmes. It supports the development of a quality culture in which all internal stakeholders assume responsibility for quality and engage in quality assurance at all levels of the institution. In order to facilitate this, the policy has a formal status and is publicly available.

The policy translates into practice through a variety of internal quality assurance processes that allow participation across the institution. How the policy is implemented, monitored and revised is the institution's decision.

STANDARD 7: INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT AND FACILITIES

Expectation

The institution's support and the financial resources for the programme must be sufficient to provide an environment in which the programme can achieve its objectives and retain its strength. Also, the institutional facilities, including library, classrooms and offices, must be adequate to support the objective of the programme. To satisfy this criterion a number of standards must be met.

Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs)

7.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): There must be sufficient support and financial resources to attract and retain high-quality teaching staff and provide the means for them to maintain competence as teachers and scholars.

7.1.1 Describe how the programme meets this standard. If it does not, explain the main causes and plans to rectify the situation.

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7.1.2 Describe the level of adequacy of secretarial support, technical staff and office Equipment

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7.2 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): There must be an appropriate number of high-quality graduate students, research assistants and PhD students.

7.2.1 Provide the number of graduate students, research assistants and PhD students for the last three years.

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7.2.2 Provide the teacher: graduate student ratio for the last three years

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7.3 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): Financial resources must be provided to acquire and maintain library holdings, laboratories and computing facilities.

7.3.1 Describe the resources available for the library.

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7.3.2 Describe the resources available for laboratories.

7.3.3 Describe the resources available for computing facilities.

7.4 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): The institution must have the infrastructure to support new trends in learning such as e learning.

7.4.1 Describe infrastructure and facilities that support new trends in learning.

7.4.2 Indicate how adequate the facilities are.

7.5 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): The library must possess an up-to-date technical collection relevant to the programme and must be adequately staffed with professional personnel.

7.5.1 Describe the adequacy of the library's technical collection.

7.5.2 Describe the support rendered by the library.

7.6 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): Classrooms must be adequately equipped, and offices must be adequate to enable teaching staff to carry out their responsibilities.

7.6.1 Describe the adequacy of the classrooms.

7.6.2 Describe the adequacy of teaching staff offices.

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Indicative evidence

- Comprehensive analysis reports of student support services accessible to students and other stakeholders
- Mechanism for resolutions of student grievances and complaints
- Review reports of student involvement and satisfaction with the provided academic support services, co-curricular and extracurricular activities
- Periodic assessment reports of student support and advising services with practicable recommendations for further improvement
- Video evidence of resources
- Print or electronic review reports of availability of required students' support and advisory services reflected through student handbooks, catalogues, newspapers
- Review reports of programme resources, fund raising and grant activities
- Review of periodic reports of programme planning, assessment and budget
- Review reports of work of various programme committees dealing with resource acquiring, allocation or replacement, and so on
- Review reports of resource availability and allocation and linkage with planning cycle
- Review reports of transparency of the system of all kinds of contracts and agreements regarding resource acquiring and sharing
- Review reports of endowment policies and procedures, if any
- Review reports of resource management.

Guidelines

For a good higher education experience, programmes provide a range of resources to assist student learning. These vary from physical resources such as libraries, study facilities and IT infrastructure to human support in the form of tutors, counsellors and other advisers. The role of support services is of particular importance in facilitating the mobility of students within and across higher education systems.

The needs of a diverse student population (such as mature, part-time, employed and international students as well as students with disabilities), and the shift towards studentcentred

learning and flexible modes of learning and teaching, are taken into account when allocating, planning and providing the learning resources and student support.

Support activities and facilities may be organised in a variety of ways depending on the institutional context and subject requirements. However, the internal quality assurance ensures that all resources are fit for purpose, accessible, and that students are informed about the services available to them.

In delivering support services the role of support and administrative staff is crucial and therefore they need to be qualified and have opportunities to develop their competences

STANDARD 8: INSTITUTIONAL GENERAL REQUIREMENTS

Expectation

The institution ensures that research degrees are awarded in a research environment that provides secure academic Precepts, standards and international best practices for doing research and learning about research approaches, methods, procedures and protocols, and which takes account of social and industrial needs. This environment offers students quality opportunities and the support they need to achieve successful academic, personal and professional outcomes from their research degrees.

8.1 Expectation outcome indicators (EOIs): General Principles

8.1.1. Full and part-time postgraduate research programmes will only be offered where students can be expected to meet the academic Precepts the institution has set for itself, which should reflect national expectations.

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8.1.2 Regulations should be clearly defined, made readily available and be sufficiently comprehensive to cover the progression of research students from admission and registration through to final examination and award.

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8.1.3. Regulations should be subject to regular review, at local and institutional level.

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8.1.4. Research should take account of regional, national and international social and industrial needs.

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8.2: The research environment

The institution should:

8.2.1 only offer research opportunities where students can be trained and supported within an environment that is supportive of research

8.2.2. make sure that all publicity materials associated with postgraduate research programmes are clear, accurate and of sufficient detail to inform student choice.

8.3: The selection and admission of students

The institution should:

8.3.1. make sure that admissions procedures are clear and consistently applied

8.3.2. make sure that only appropriately qualified and/or prepared students are admitted onto research programmes

8.3.3. make sure that admissions decisions involve the judgment of more than one member of the institution's staff with relevant expertise

Evidence: Admission Committee

8.3.4. make sure that admissions procedures promote equality of opportunity

8.3.5. make sure that the entitlements and responsibilities of a research student undertaking a postgraduate research programme at the institution are defined and communicated clearly

8.4: Student information and induction

The institution should:

8.4.1: make sure that research students are provided with opportunities by the institution to enable them to commence their studies with an understanding of the academic and social environment within which they will be working.

8.5: The approval of research projects

The institution should:

8.5.1: give adequate consideration to the feasibility of both full and part-time students undertaking and successfully completing a particular research project.

8.6: Skills training

The institution should:

8.6.1: make sure that research students have access to training sufficient to gain the skills they need to design and complete their programmes effectively and to help prepare themselves for their subsequent career.

8.7: Supervision

The institution should:

8.7.1: make sure that supervisors possess recognized subject expertise

8.7.2: make sure that supervisors have the necessary skills and experience to monitor, support and direct research students' work

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8.7.3: make sure that research students receive support and direction sufficient to enable them to succeed in their studies

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8.7.4: make sure that the progress made by research students is consistently monitored and regularly communicated to the students.

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8.8: Assessment

The institution should:

8.8.1: make sure that postgraduate research assessment processes are communicated clearly and fully to research students and supervisors

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8.8.2: postgraduate research assessment processes are clear and operated rigorously, fairly, reliably and consistently

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Feedback, complaints and appeals

8.8.3: make sure that mechanisms exist to enable open and constructive feedback to be provided by research students and their supervisors on the learning experience and support infrastructure

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8.8.4: make sure that complaints and appeals procedures are fair, open and consistently applied, allowing students access to relevant information and an opportunity to present a case

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8.8.5: make sure that independent and formal procedures exist to deal swiftly with complaints from research students about the quality of the institution's learning and support provision

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8.8.6: make sure that formal procedures exist to deal with any academic appeals made by postgraduate research students

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8.8.7: make sure that the acceptable grounds for appeals are clearly defined

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Evaluation

The institution should:

I make sure that the extent to which institutions are discharging their responsibilities for the Precepts of the research awards granted in their name, and for the quality of the education provided to enable research students to attain those Precepts, are regularly reviewed.

Indicative evidence

General principles

The expectation for general principles might be evidenced by the institution's:

- institutional regulations.

The research environment

The expectation for the research environment might be evidenced by the institution's:

- information about what constitutes a successful community of academic staff and postgraduate students engaged in research
- information about the quality of supervision available, including the research skills of prospective supervisors
- information about the facilities and equipment that will be made available to research students
- information about what provision should be made available to develop research and employment-related skills
- information about access to academic and welfare support facilities
- information about the opportunities for effective student representation
- information about what implementation and monitoring mechanisms need to be applied where a project is undertaken in collaboration with another organisation.

The selection and admission of students

The expectation for the selection and admission of students might be evidenced by the institution's:

- information about how to ensure that suitably experienced and trained staff are used in the selection process
- information about how interviews with candidates might be used as part of the admissions process (including arrangements for assessing the suitability of candidates based overseas)
- information about the use, where a prospective student lacks a first degree and/or a taught postgraduate award, of alternative mechanisms for assessing student qualification and preparedness, reflecting professional or other work experience
- information about the use of references and other information in helping to assess the suitability of a candidate to undertake postgraduate research
- information about whether the prospective student has, or is likely to secure, the necessary financial support to undertake their studies
- information about the assurance of language proficiency, particularly where programmes involve work in a language other than the candidate's native language.

The definition of minimum proficiency levels and the provision of in-house training should be considered

- information about the balance of responsibilities between staff in local units and central postgraduate administration
- information about the maintenance of confidentiality throughout the admissions process.

Student information and induction

The expectation for student information and induction might be evidenced by the institution's:

- information about the institution and its postgraduate portfolio
- information about the challenges that will typically face research students during the course of their studies and where guidance may be sought in the event of difficulties
- information about the institution's registration, enrolment, appeals and complaints procedures, assessment requirements, and research degree regulations
- information about the facilities that will be made available to the student and the institution's learning support infrastructure
- information about relevant health and safety and other legislative information; information about student welfare
- information about supervision arrangements, including evaluation, monitoring and review procedures
- information about skills training programmes (both those available and those that may be required)
- information about the opportunities that exist for meeting other research students, faculty and staff; information about the opportunities that exist to develop scholarly competence and independence of mind; postgraduate research programmes
- information about the opportunities that exist to share experience and understanding beyond a research student's immediate study area.

The approval of research projects

The expectation for the approval of research projects might be evidenced by the institution's:

- information about how to establish a clear project proposal and the objectives of the project
- information about the relationship between the approval of the research project by academic peers and the admission of the student to the postgraduate programme
- information about the skills, knowledge and aptitude required by student and supervisor for successful completion of the project
- information about the resources (including staffing and facilities) needed to support the research project and arrangements for monitoring the continued availability of such resources

- information about arrangements for support and monitoring of students' progress during extended periods of off-campus fieldwork or work in collaborating organisations.

Skills training

The expectation for skills training might be evidenced by the institution's:

- information about how students are enabled to develop analytical and research skills, including the understanding of project design and research methodologies, appropriate to the subject and programme of study
- information about how students are enabled to develop general and employment-related skills, including, for example, interpersonal and teamworking skills; project management, information retrieval and database management, written and oral presentational skills, career planning and advice and intellectual property rights management
- information about how students are enabled to develop language support and academic writing skills
- information about how students are enabled to develop training and support for those researchers who may be involved in teaching and demonstrating activities.

Supervision

The expectation for supervision might be evidenced by the institution's:

- information about the provision of training for supervisors and continuing faculty/staff development; information about the provision of a point of contact if a supervisory team is appointed
- information about alternative arrangements where the supervisor(s) is unavailable to act for a temporary or extended period
- information about arrangements that ensure that supervisors are not overloaded
- frameworks for regular supervisor/research student interaction, with a minimum frequency of (and responsibility for initiating) scheduled review meetings between the student, supervisor(s) and, if appropriate, other individuals
- arrangements that enable students to be introduced to other researchers (and appropriate academic bodies and societies) in their field
- information about routes for the research student and supervisor(s) to seek independent advice should communication links within the relationship break down
- information about how support is provided to the supervisor(s) where serious concerns of student ability or application to the study programme have been identified
- information about the nature and frequency of contact between the supervisor(s) and research student

- information about the nature and adequacy of monitoring reports (including their production and agreement, institutional review mechanisms and feedback arrangements)
- information about the mechanisms for advising research students if desired academic Precepts have not yet been, or are unlikely to be, achieved
- information about the provision of counselling and advisory services
- information about the transfer arrangements between registration categories
- information about the mechanisms by which decisions to suspend or terminate a research student's registration may be taken.

Assessment

The expectation for assessment might be evidenced by the institution's:

- information about the form in which postgraduate research assessment regulations and information should be made available to their research students, faculty/staff and external examiners, and how they draw attention to any exceptions or additional requirements that apply
- information about the timing of the provision of such information
- information about the mechanisms used for communicating deadlines in respect of the submission of research project work
- information about the mechanisms used for communicating procedures relating to the nomination of examiners, the examination process (including any oral examination), the process and time taken to reach a decision and the potential outcomes of the assessment
- information about the mechanisms used for the identification and maintenance of Precepts of research student achievement
- information about procedures for the appointment of at least two examiners of a postgraduate research dissertation or thesis, of whom at least one should be external to the institution
- information about how to ensure that assessment is undertaken only by those individuals with relevant qualifications and experience and with a clear understanding of the task
- information about under what circumstances (if at all) a student's supervisor should be an examiner
- information about the avoidance of conflicts of interest between internal or external examiners and researchers who have had a substantial direct involvement in the research student's work or whose work is the focus of the research project
- information about how students declare that the material presented for examination is their own work and has not been submitted for any other award (and, where relevant, how it relates to a group project)
- information about communication to the student and any sponsor of assessment outcomes and any consequent procedures

- information about the mechanisms used to secure and promulgate feedback
- information about representation on institutional progress monitoring and decisionmaking bodies
- information that demonstrates that the appeals procedures are clear and well publicised and serve to protect the rights of all concerned
- information about what mechanisms are used to communicate appeals procedures, how students may lodge an appeal and how decisions are taken to grant an appeal hearing
- information about the constitution of an appeals panel, and the relation of its members to those involved in the original assessment decision, how records are maintained of an appeal hearing and the mechanisms for communicating the results of an appeal hearing to interested parties.

Evaluation

The expectation for evaluation might be evidenced by:

- the time taken to submit these and other materials for assessment
- pass and fail rates
- feedback received from research students and employers
- career progression information relating to full and, where appropriate, part-time research students
- comments received from external examiners
- the extent to which institutional research training programmes meet the Precepts set for such provision by the institution
- feedback received from research students, employers, sponsors and any other external funders.

Guidelines

This relates to higher education research in the specific context of research degrees and particular requirements for doctorates and research master's degrees. It refers to the research environment and the supervisory process which are distinct requirements of research degrees and enable higher education institutions to provide an effective student experience and maintain academic Precepts for research degrees.